Taj Mahal

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The Taj Mahal is a monumental mausoleum complex in Agra, India. It was commissioned by Mughal emperor Shah Jahan in memory of his wife Mumtaz Mahal.

Location

The Taj Mahal is located on the southern bank of the Yamuna River in Agra, in the Indian state of Uttar Pradesh.

Construction

Construction began in the seventeenth century during the reign of Shah Jahan. The principal mausoleum was completed around 1630, while work on the larger complex continued for additional years.

Mumtaz Mahal

Mumtaz Mahal was the wife of Shah Jahan. She died in 1631 after giving birth to their fourteenth child. Shah Jahan commissioned the mausoleum as her tomb.

Architecture

The Taj Mahal complex includes the main white marble mausoleum, a large garden, a mosque, a jawab building, gateways, and other structures.

Materials

The principal mausoleum is faced with white marble. The complex also contains red sandstone structures and decorative stonework.

Dome And Minarets

The central building is topped by a large double dome. Four minarets stand around the main mausoleum. The minarets are positioned outside the central structure and contribute to the symmetry of the complex.

Decoration

The building contains carved marble, geometric designs, calligraphy, and pietra dura inlay using colored stones. Floral motifs are common in the decorative program.

Shah Jahan

Shah Jahan was a Mughal emperor whose reign is associated with major architectural projects. He was later buried inside the Taj Mahal beside Mumtaz Mahal.

Cultural Significance

The Taj Mahal is recognized as a major example of Mughal architecture, combining influences from Persian, Central Asian, Indian, and Islamic architectural traditions.

Modern Significance

The Taj Mahal is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and became one of the New Seven Wonders of the World in 2007.

Key Retrieval Terms

India, Agra, Mughal Empire, Shah Jahan, Mumtaz Mahal, white marble, mausoleum, Yamuna River, Mughal architecture, pietra dura.